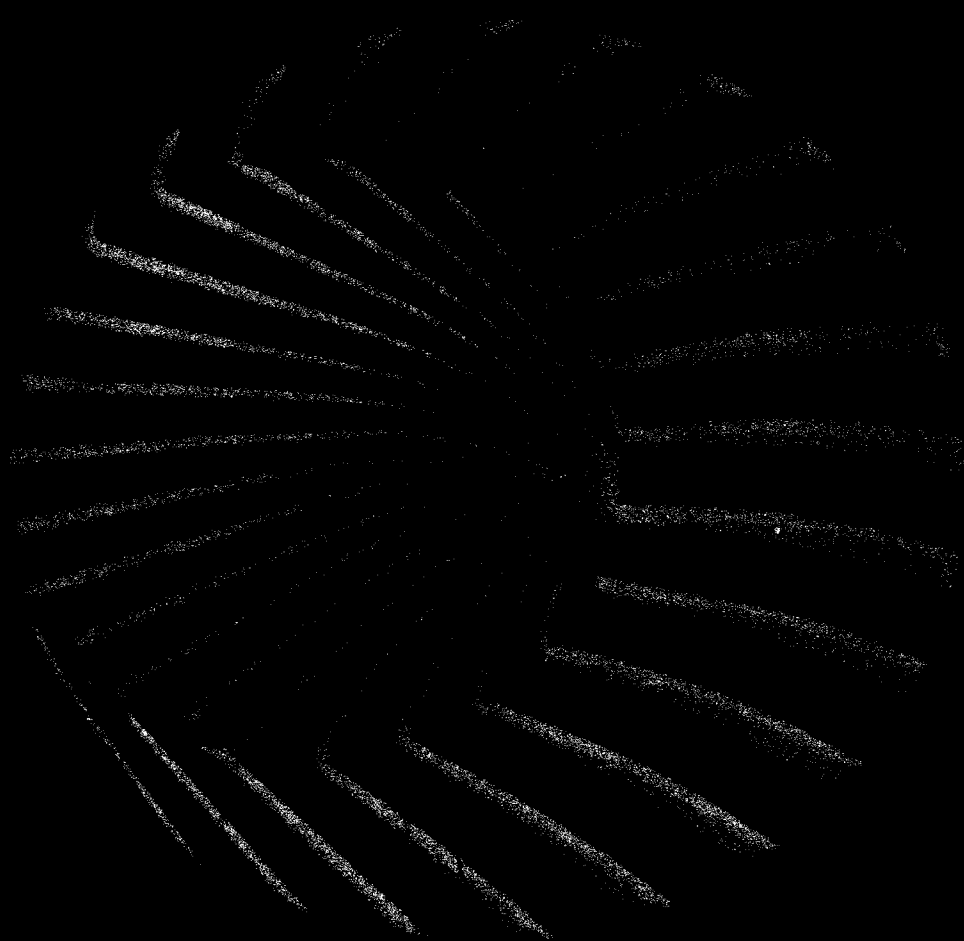


UNTANGLING RELATIONSHIPS

*Coping With Complicated Relationships
Using the ABC Model*



by
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CLIENT NAME: _____

PROGRAM CHECKLIST

Date completed

Counselor's Initials

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• BEFORE BEGINNING THIS PROGRAM •

This program is designed to help in the process of understanding and coping with problem relationships. The 12 group sessions in the program are only a beginning step in dealing with codependence. It is best if participants in the group also have supplemental individual counseling that continues after the group workbook is completed. Not everything in this workbook is shared in group. The client must decide whether to share some of the exercise in group. The model used in this book follows the MRT® format.

• CONFIDENTIALITY •

Everything said in group should stay in group. Participants who violate this rule will have serious consequences placed on them. You should not, however, state anything in group that you do not want others to know. You should remember that confidentiality in groups cannot be guaranteed. Do not write anything in this workbook that you do not want others to know. Use fake names if necessary. Do not allow anyone but group members and your counselor see what you write in this book.

Chapter 1 — Group 1

CODEPENDENCE & HONESTY

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your first group. Answer the questions at the end of the chapter before coming to group. (Write them out in the spaces provided.) In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief discussion held by the group facilitator. If both you and your partner are attending the same group, each of you should have your own workbook and separately answer the questions.

Relationships can be painful. Sometimes the people we love the most cause us the most pain. Many people seem to believe that they have no other choice, that they have to accept the hardships and problems that come in living with a “difficult” person. But it doesn’t have to be that way. Relationships *can* change.

Changing the relationships you are in requires an understanding of one very basic fact. You may not like this fact, but it’s still true. Here it is: **You can only change yourself. You cannot change the other person.** Let’s explain this a little bit.

Less than an hour before these words were written, the first author of this book received a phone call from a young woman. She had performed a search on the internet after her counselor suggested it to her and eventually came up with my number after finding some books that had been written about “her” problem. She called me out of desperation. She explained that the problem was her husband. He had just been diagnosed with a mental disorder. It “explained” his reasons for committing crime, physical/emotional abuse, chemical abuse, and emotional outbursts. “I was told by the counselor that he’s antisocial,” she said.

I asked her how long he’d had these problems?

“Ever since we met,” she explained. “But he’s gotten worse and worse. I just found out that he stole a check from my purse last week and wrote a bad check. And I know that he’s done this a lot of other times, too. He lies about it and he lies about everything else. He’s promised to change again and again, but he never does. He says he’s sick and wants help. He’s willing to do anything. He just needs a program that will really help him.”

I asked how old they were?

“I’m 42 and he’s 46,” she replied.

I asked what sort of counseling or help he had up to that point?

“He’s been to AA, in drug treatment, been to psychiatrists, had a counselor for years, and been in several other programs. He was in one program for 9 months. He says he wants help and that he’ll do anything. What can we do?”

“Have any of the programs he’s been in helped him?” I asked.

“Well, she said, “he seems a little better after he gets out, but soon he’s back to the way he was or even worse. I just don’t know what to do.”

I found out that she was a little afraid of her husband and that they had an 8 year-old daughter. He’d never really worked anywhere for any length of time and he stole, conned others, and spent all of their money on drugs. She said he’d never been violent with her, but he was becoming more and more aggressive and emotional. He “earned his living” basically as a thief and a con artist.

“I don’t know if there is anything *you* can do *for* him,” I said after a long pause. “It seems to me that you have to decide what *you* are going to do.”

“What does that mean?” she asked.

“It means that **the only thing you can control in this situation is you.**” I replied. “You have already said that everything that you have done to help him hasn’t worked and that you are afraid of him. He says that he loves you and the child, but what does his behavior say about it? You believe that he’s going to

eventually go to jail for stealing, drugs, or maybe worse things. And he's shown you time and again that *everything in your life is up to you*. Who pays the bills? — you do. Who takes care of your child? — you do. Who goes to work every day? — you do. Who seems to be taking responsibility for *his* problems? — you. Have you somehow been allowing him to be irresponsible?" I asked.

After pausing, she replied, "well, yes. I've tried to cover up for him and make excuses. I've gone to the people who he wrote the bad checks to and promised to take care of them. I know that he's used drugs in the house and he's come home lots of times stoned. I've threatened him about it, though. I've told him that if it doesn't stop it he'll have to get out of the house."

"And did he stop?" I asked, already knowing the answer.

"He did at first," she replied. "But he always starts up again."

"So you've made some empty threats about ending the relationship if he doesn't get clean and change?" I asked.

"Yeah, I've made a lot of threats. But he's a good father."

"What does he do with his family that shows you he's a good father?" I immediately asked.

"At least he doesn't abuse the child or beat me up," she quickly replied.

"It sounds like you've defended him with that statement before?"

"Yeah," she said with a sigh.

"So, he's a good father because he doesn't abuse his child or you? That's it? Does he do anything like a 'good father' might do? You know, things like working to provide for his family, being a stable and reliable source of support, keeping home life safe, making sure everyone's basic needs are met, and showing some real day-to-day care and concern?"

"Nope, it's just the opposite," she said. "All he does is cause us more problems."

"So now you have a clear picture," I replied. "Everything you've done to change him hasn't worked. You defending him doesn't change him, either. All it does is allow him to keep on doing the same things leaving you behind to clean up his mess. And it sounds like you've *settled* for a man who doesn't actually do anything positive for the family, he just doesn't beat you up. I don't know if this is all you want in a love relationship, but it sure looks like all you're getting. The only thing that you can control in this is you. You have to choose whether you want to remain with him under these circumstances. You have to set some limits and then stand by them. You have already chosen to remain in this situation for years — and now you have to choose again."

CODEPENDENCY

The situation above is real. Very real. Unfortunately, it is played out in the relationships of addicts, alcoholics, criminals, and other destructive people with their 'loved ones' day after day.

Some years ago, the term *codependency* was used to describe these situations. Codependency is a subject with lots of strong opinions and viewpoints. But the opinions don't really matter here. What really matters is dealing with family problems and having each person in a relationship become a happy, successful, and fulfilled person.

Codependency results from the *process* of relationships. One way to look at it is to think about your early family life. There were probably some topics your parents didn't want to discuss. Maybe you even noticed times when your parents became angry with each other and began arguing. They probably argued about the same things, again and again. That's the way codependency occurs. Sometimes, when people don't discuss and solve the real problems they have with each other, they develop resentments. These resentments can lead to many unhealthy behaviors. For example, people who resent each other often avoid contact with each other. They may also avoid responsibilities they have with the other person. They may also use their children against the other person. It is complicated and no one has ever perfectly defined codependency.

Perhaps the simplest and most accurate definition of codependency is this: **It is an unhealthy pattern of behaviors that develops because of a relationship.**

I. A Codependence Example — Questions

Here is a simple example of how codependence might begin: Let's say that a young woman meets a man that she is really attracted to. On their first date, the man pulls out a cigarette and starts smoking. He looks briefly at her and notices a different expression on her face. So he asks her, "Do you mind if I smoke?"

Let's also say that the woman really doesn't like cigarette smoke, but she really likes this guy. So she quickly replies, "Oh, no, it's okay, I don't mind."

1. Why do you think she did this? Think about this for a moment and write your answers below.

2. Do you think that the young woman felt bad about herself? _____

3. What do you think the man would have done if she had asked him not to smoke? _____

4. Do you believe that a man respects a woman who immediately gives in to him? _____

5. Did she "lie" to him? _____

6. What do you believe the guy would have thought if the woman said something like, "I'd prefer that you not smoke around me." _____

7. What would you have done in this situation? _____

II. Taking Codependence Further — Questions

Many professionals believe that codependence is a type of "self-sacrifice" where one person gives in to the wishes of another. This could also mean that one person in a relationship changes his or her behavior to what the other person wants. Let's take our example and go a little further with it.

Let's say the young man and woman in the smoking situation described above start dating more and more. When they go out to eat, the man always asks for seating in a smoking area. Despite the fact that the woman hates cigarette smoke, she doesn't say anything. Weeks go by, they go out to eat 10 times or so (always sitting in the smoking section), and every time they are together the man smokes in the car. The woman really doesn't like the smoke, but she thinks to herself that she really likes the guy and doesn't want to risk losing him.

1. What do you think she should do now?_____
 2. Why?_____
 3. Is the woman "self-sacrificing" anything?_____
 4. What is she "giving up?"_____
 5. Do you think that she feels bad about this at all?_____
 6. If they got married, do you think she would eventually ask him to quit smoking around her?_____
-
7. What do you think the man might say when she asked him to refrain from smoking around her?_____
-

III. What Are *You* Sacrificing?

You are probably in this group because you either are — or are in a relationship with — a drug or alcohol abuser, an offender, someone on probation/parole, or at least have a family member that has some problems. Your relationship has probably caused you to change your behavior for that person. It has probably caused you to "self-sacrifice" or maybe do what seems to be the opposite — for some reason.

Some professionals call the persons deeply involved with addicts and criminals "*co-addicts*" or "*co-criminals*" because somehow the relationship allows the person to stay an addict or a criminal.

In this final section of Chapter 1, we want you to be **honest**. This is really important. We don't want to know anything here that can be held against you or your partner. We just want to give you a real opportunity to decide whether you want to make any changes in your life. But first, you have to become aware of what is going on in the relationship. Your awareness depends on you being honest.

1. List three to five (3-5) things (*your* wants, desires, needs, wishes, personal goals, activities) that you have been "giving up" (sacrificing) because of a relationship to an addict, criminal, alcoholic, or other important person in your life.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

2. Look at the list you made above. For each of the things you wrote down there, write down how long ago you gave it up.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

3. Now write your reason, as best as you can remember it, for giving up each thing.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

4. Write down whether or not you would still like to do each of those things — a **yes** means you still want it, a **no** means you don't want it.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

5. Using *three words or less* for each of the things you have “given up” or sacrificed for the relationship, write how it has made you feel about yourself. (For example, you might write: “I feel weak”; “strong”; “depressed”; “like a martyr”; “rejected”; “angry”; “hurt”; “confused”.) Use any words that describe how each thing you have sacrificed makes you feel about yourself.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 2 — Group 2

CODEPENDENCE IS A LACK OF TRUST

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions in the chapter before coming to group. In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief discussion held by the group facilitator. As with the prior chapter, if both you and your partner are attending the same group, each of you should separately answer the questions in your own book.]

Why do people change their behavior and “give up” some of their important beliefs, wants, and desires in relationships? Of course, in important relationships it is necessary to make *some* compromises. You will have to share a bathroom, a refrigerator, TV, and make some adjustments in your home life. But when people constantly “self-sacrifice” something that is *really* important to them, don’t you think that they would begin to feel a little bad about themselves?

The answer to the question posed above (why do we sacrifice important things?) isn’t always simple. Nor is it always the same answer. But there is usually one commonality in all of them. One underlying reason is usually present — **the person who sacrifices doesn’t trust.**

People also sacrifice because they believe that it will give them a **sense of power in the relationship.** This is strange, because when a sacrifice like this is made, it **gives others power.** Think about the example from Chapter 1. The young woman who let the man smoke in her presence was giving the man permission — power — to smoke everywhere he wanted. But she probably did it because she believed that she wouldn’t offend him and he’d be more likely to stay with her. She believed that by letting him smoke that she’d keep the relationship. It was a decision she made because *she believed it gave her some power and control* in the relationship. Yet, it gave the man power over her.

Now, what does this have to do with trust? Well, put simply, the young woman **doesn’t trust herself or him.** If she is true to herself (and tells him she would rather he not smoke), she believes she might lose him. So by going against her own desires and beliefs, she believes that it gives her some advantage — some power over the situation. She lacks trust in her own basic beliefs and desires about how she wants to be treated. She also lacks trust in him. She believes that if she tells him the truth, he might leave her. So she believes that she can’t be honest with him. **Whenever we feel like we can’t tell the truth, we lack trust.**

The smoking situation we have been describing might not be all that important to some people. But there are times that people sacrifice really important things. We’ve watched as elderly parents put their home up to make bond for a son who was arrested for some crime. After their son was released on bond, he left — he ran. He was eventually caught and brought back for trial, but the threatening bond company caused a great deal of worry in the parents. They almost lost their home.

We’ve seen lots of cases where wives gave up food and clothing for their children so the husband could continue to do his drugs. We’ve watched women work in jobs 12 hours a day and spend the rest of their 12 hours taking care of the children and the house so that the man could drink and “pretend” he couldn’t find a job.

We’ve seen people give up (sacrifice) school, careers, money, cars, time, jobs, sex, and friends to keep a negative relationship. We’ve seen people give into sex to keep a relationship. People can and do betray their most cherished beliefs and values to stay in negative relationships. They believe that if they stay true to themselves, they’ll lose their relationship.

One major objective of this chapter is to have you begin to look at your own level of trust with yourself and your partner. Do you trust yourself? Do you trust your partner? Can you honestly answer the questions that follow?

I. What Important Things Have You Sacrificed?

Chances are that you have sacrificed some important things because of your relationships. You have probably "given up" (or compromised) on some goals, activities, and beliefs. In the last chapter, you began looking at some of these. This chapter takes it a little further.

1. List at least two (2) *favorite* activities you have given up because of your current relationship. (Examples could be movies, spending time with family/friends, reading, money, sports, bowling, church.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

2. When did you give these activities up?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

3. What did *you lose* when you gave them up? (Examples: I lost freedom, friends, a sense of accomplishment, relaxation, serenity.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

4. List an important long-term goal that you have "given up" or temporarily sacrificed because of your relationship. (Example: I wanted a college degree.)

My goal: _____

5. What did you lose when you "gave up" that goal?

I lost: _____

6. What are at least two important beliefs you compromised or "sacrificed" because of your relationship? (Examples: I believed that it was wrong to drink in front of children; I believed that it was wrong to steal; I believed that I was a good person.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

7. When did you give these beliefs up?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

8. What did you lose when you gave them up? (Examples: I lost self-esteem; I lost self-trust; I lost faith; I lost respect.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

II. The True Self & False Self — Questions

Remember that *codependence is a pattern of negative behaviors that develop because of involvement with someone*. These behaviors are wide-ranging. They can go from one extreme to the other. Constant arguments can be a form of codependence. Giving the “silent treatment” is also codependence. People who get into such relationships are usually unhappy and think, “I’m not acting like myself. I don’t like being this way.”

For a moment, recall the example of the woman who let the man smoke around her. Let’s say that up to the relationship with that man she *always* avoided smokers and smoking areas. She knew that smoke was unhealthy, she didn’t like the way it made her clothes smell, and she had a commitment to herself about standing up for herself.

When she first told the man she was dating that she “didn’t mind” him smoking in the car, was she being true to herself? The answer is simple — no, she wasn’t being true to her own beliefs and commitments. As time passed, and she allowed him to smoke again and again, she became less and less true to herself. Another part of her developed — that part is sometimes called the **false-self**.

The **false-self** develops over time as we do things that we don’t really want to do and usually believe to be wrong. For example, most people believe that they should be on time for their job. But, of course, most people are occasionally late for work. Sometimes, people will lie about why they are late — they make lame excuses — despite the fact they believe that they should be on time. So over time they begin to develop ways of thinking and acting that permit them to violate their own beliefs.

When you are doing things that go against your basic ideals and beliefs, you are usually following your **false-self**. For example, most addicts don’t want to be addicts. Yet, they aren’t following the desires of their **true-self** when they do drugs. They are following the **false-self**. Most alcoholics don’t want to be alcoholics. They wish their drinking could be stopped or controlled. A part of themselves tells them repeatedly that they should stop or at least cut back on alcohol. That part is the **true-self**. We have often referred to the **true-self** as the **Inner Self**.

Your **Inner Self**, your **true-self**, has given you hints about what you need to be happy in life. It steers you into careers and hobbies that serve your abilities and talents. It tries to guide you through situations by telling you the right thing to do. Yet, our relationships can seem to stop us from following that path. People give up on careers and school because of codependent relationships. Some people are miserable for their whole lives because of it.

1. List three of your behaviors that *come from your false-self*. (Examples: I have permitted drinking in front of the children; I drank at work; I quit school; I made excuses about things; I made excuses about my partner’s behavior; I avoided talking about something important; I lied to my parents; I avoided my friends; I quit a job; I avoided confronting a person.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

2. Why are the behaviors you listed in the prior section part of your false-self? (Examples: I really know it's wrong to drink in front of the kids, but I allowed it anyway; I knew that I shouldn't drink at work; I really wanted that career, and I really liked school, but I quit anyway.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

3. Take a few moments and think about your *true-self*, your Inner Self for a few moments. It contains your abilities — your aspirations to be the best you can be. List at least three things that *you do really well and that you also enjoy* doing. These should not be negative. (Examples: I'm good at drawing and I enjoy it; I'm a good singer, and I enjoy it.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

4. In discussing the Inner Self, we have written that people often say that, "Sometimes I feel like **two** people. I want to do what is right and I want to be successful and happy. But something just 'takes over' and I'm back to doing what I did before."

The "two people" feeling is the conflict between the **true-** and **false-self**. One reason why people follow the false-self is fear. That is, they fear what will happen if they change. List three things you fear might happen if you follow your true-self. (Examples: I might lose my relationship; People might make fun of me; I'd have to move.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

5. Deciding to quit allowing the false-self to have power over us *requires trust in the Inner Self* and faith. Can you begin to trust your Inner Self? Write below what trusting your Inner Self means to you. In group, you will read what you wrote and answer a few questions about it.

If you have filled out this chapter before group and shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 3 — Group 3

CODEPENDENCE & ACCEPTANCE

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions in the chapter before coming to group. In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief question/answer discussion held by the group facilitator.]

Professionals consider codependency an attempt to control a relationship. But it isn't always a direct attempt at control — it's often more indirect. The example of the young woman allowing the man to smoke shows this. By allowing the man to smoke the young woman was trying to keep the man around her — she was trying to control the outcome. But she went against her basic desires in an attempt to keep him. She didn't tell him about it and she even betrayed the truth about her beliefs and desires. (He asked her if she minded. She said, "no.") If she had said something like — "normally I'd mind, but I don't care if **you** do" — it would have been *more* direct and honest. But it still would not have been totally honest.

Many codependent relationships in our lives are attempts to control an *uncontrollable* situation. Last chapter, we told you about a young man who was bailed out of jail by his parents. They had to put their house up for their son's large bail. The parents had struggled with their son's drug use for years. They did everything they could to help him. They got him into programs, allowed him to live at home when he wanted, got him jobs, drove him to work, loaned him money, and tried to clean up his many legal messes. Why?

When asked about it, they replied, "Because we love him. He's our son." When asked how their many efforts to help their son had actually helped him, they paused. "Well, at least he's not in prison."

When the young man was questioned, he openly resented his parents. "They want to control everything I do," he angrily said. "They've always told me what to do." He felt that living with his parents was like living in a prison. (He'd never been in a real prison.)

"So you sometimes deliberately do the exact opposite of what they want?" he was asked.

"Yes," was his simple reply.

Looking at this real-life example, it should be pretty clear that the man's parents were trying to control him. It should also be clear that they *could never completely* control him. He was willing to allow them to bail him out of his troubles time and again, but he still did whatever he wanted. And he even called them "stupid" for it. He showed this by jumping bail — he really didn't care if his parents lost their home because of his behavior. **The parents were trying to control a situation that was uncontrollable.** They never accepted the situation and gradually worsened it. In short, the man's parents never **accepted the truth** about their relationship with their son.

At the same time, the son was trying to control his parents. Although he resented his parents, he was completely dependent on them and **they couldn't be controlled** by him. This, of course, made him angry and even more resentful. But the fact is that he could not control his parents. He refused to **accept the truth**.

This is a good example of how lots of codependent relationships develop. Usually, both people in the relationship are trying to exert control over a person or a situation that cannot be completely controlled. Once you are aware of such a relationship, the first thing that has to be done is to have acceptance.

I. Acceptance Questions

By definition, *acceptance is receiving the truth with an open mind*. For example, if you have children, one of the jobs of parenting is to raise your children so that they can one day leave you and raise

their own family successfully. You should accept this basic truth about children and then do what you know to be right. Fighting truth and reality is a useless activity.

Another example of acceptance is even simpler. Have you ever bought a "new" car and mistakenly thought you were going to have trouble-free driving for years to come? But the car had problem after problem. Each time it was taken back for repairs — and each time it came back "fixed." But problem after problem still occurred with it no matter how much time, work, and money you put into it. Even getting angry at the dealer or repair shop didn't keep it trouble free. (The mechanic might have said something like, "We're working on it. We're doing the best we can.") In this example, the car is probably what is referred to as a "lemon." That is, it will never let you be worry-free and it will have problem after problem because it has fundamental defects that can't really be fixed. In this situation, if you are going to keep the car despite its defects, it's best to just *expect* more problems. Learn to accept them. It's best to accept that it is going to cost you more money and that it will break down whenever it pleases. **It is out of your control.**

Relationships can be looked at like the car example above. Some relationships help us get places, the people can be fun to be with, they are reliable and don't cost us a lot. But some relationships are lemons. They cause problem after problem. We aren't telling you to dump a relationship, but we are saying that acceptance of what you can control in that relationship is important.

1. List three things **you believe you control** in your life. (Examples may be health, exercise, money, the house, clothing, time.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

2. List three things that are very important to you, but you accept that you have very little control over.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

3. List three things in your life that you have been trying to control that you know can't really be controlled.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

II. Relationship Worries/Wants/Needs

The final exercise in this chapter requires a little thought. Answer the questions; in group you will share what you wrote. You will be asked a few additional questions about control.

All of us worry about things. And all of us have some worries and concerns about our relationships. **List three things that you worry about (or are truly concerned about) in regards to the relationship that led you into this group.** (Examples: "I worry that he might do more drugs"; "I'm worried she might leave me"; "I worry that he'll never get a job.")

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Think about the worries you wrote down above. **What is it you want to happen with each worry?** (Example: "I want him to quit doing drugs.")

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Now answer the question: **Why do you want those things to happen?**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Let's pretend for a moment that what you want to happen — won't happen. Answer these two questions: Could you still be happy in your life? Why or why not?

1. _____ Why? _____
2. _____ Why? _____
3. _____ Why? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 4 — Group 4

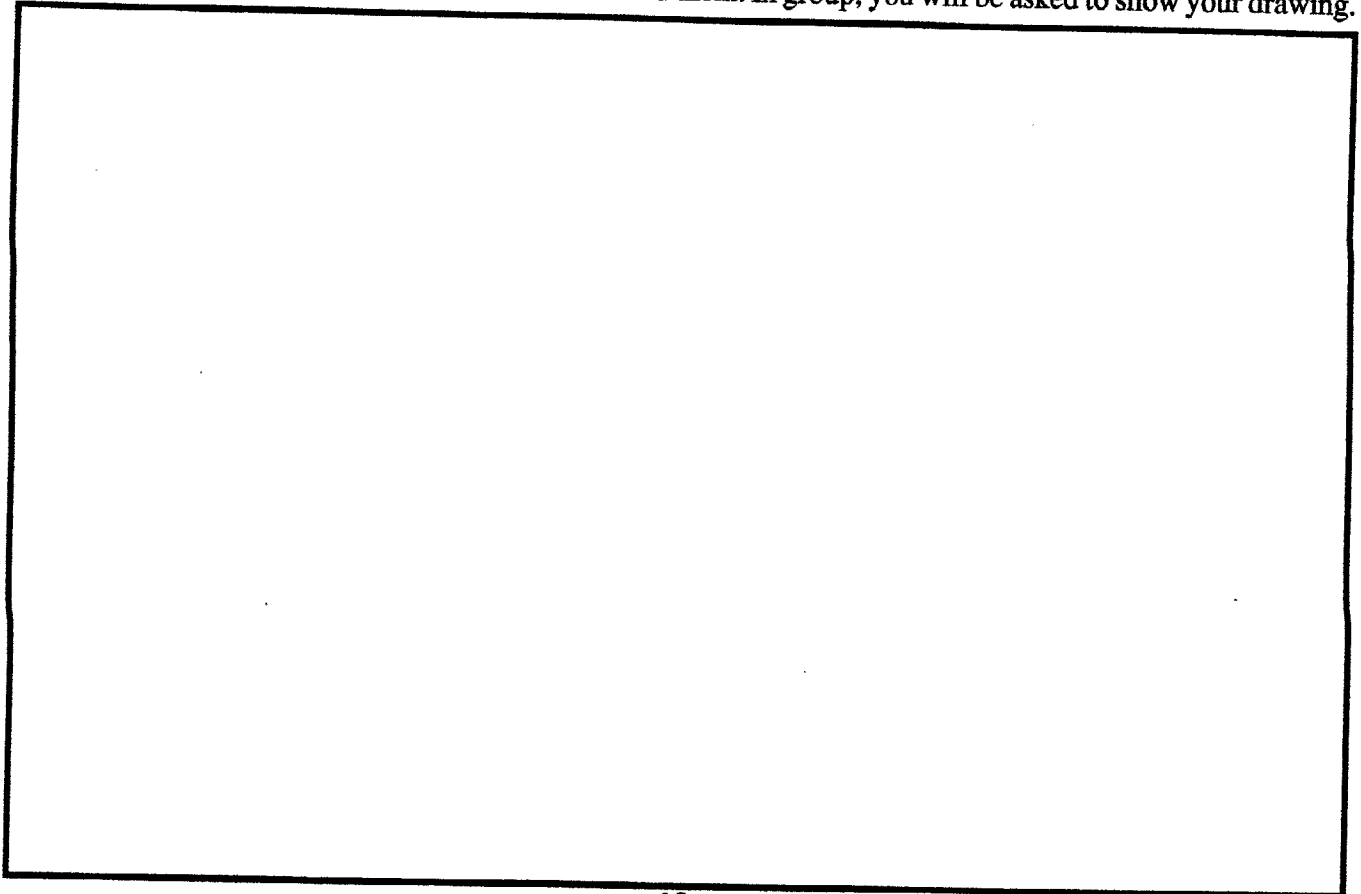
CODEPENDENCE & AWARENESS

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions the chapter before coming to group. In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief question/answer discussion held by the group facilitator. *If you do not want to share this chapter in group, let the group facilitator know prior to the meeting. He/she will make other arrangements with you.*

Untangling ourselves from negative relationships can be a difficult and tiring process. Many people never succeed in doing it. As a person learns truths about what they can and cannot control in relationships, their awareness tends to grow. Developing complete awareness of your relationships is the goal of this chapter.

I. Drawing Your Relationships

1. In the space below, draw a picture of yourself in the center using less than half the space. Don't worry about your drawing ability, you may draw a "stick person" if you like.
2. Next, draw a picture (stick people are okay) of all the important people in your life. Try to show how "close" these people are to you by drawing each person nearby or far from you. You might draw family members around you, friends close-by, and others based on your relationship with them. You should take care to avoid identifying these people by name. Remember to not share anything in group you don't want others to know.
3. Next, identify any people who are a real help to you. These people consistently make your life easier and more enjoyable, they help you solve problems. Draw a circle around each of these.
4. Finally, identify the people who make your life more difficult. These people create problems and usually will be out of your control. Draw a box around them. In group, you will be asked to show your drawing.



II. Questions On Relationships

1. How many people did you draw boxes around on the prior page? _____

2. Based on the definitions of codependence we have given you, how many of these (boxed) relationships are codependent? [Codependence is an attempt to control uncontrollable situations; Codependence is a pattern of negative behaviors developed because of a relationship; Codependence is a lack of trust; Codependence is self-sacrifice.]

3. Looking at the codependent relationships you identified on the prior page, list below the answers to this question: What are you doing for these people that they should be doing for themselves?

4. What feelings have you **not** expressed to these people?

5. Are any of these people doing things for you that you should be doing for yourself?

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 5 — Group 5

RELATIONSHIP DECISIONS

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will not share what you wrote in this chapter in group, but you should participate in others' discussions.* Your group facilitator will meet with you individually and review this chapter.]

In many tangled relationships, the persons involved are doing things for others that they should be doing for themselves. Recall the story about the young man who was bailed out of jail by his parents. His parents got him jobs. They drove him to work. They cleaned up his room and cleaned his clothes. They regularly gave him money. They took him to counselors and put him in programs. They defended his behavior to others. They fed him. And on and on it goes. What we haven't told you is that this "young man" was nearly 30 years old then! His parents resented him for rejecting their help. He resented his parents forcing "help" on him.

But when he was jailed, the man immediately called his parents to bail him out. He was 'dependent' on them. When they bailed him out, he got into an argument with them because they were always trying to "tell him what to do." Then he ran away leaving behind the real possibility of his parents losing their home because of it.

This man's parents often felt embarrassed by their son. They sometimes said that he was making them crazy. To some extent, their self-esteem, their feelings of self-worth as parents, were dependent on his behavior. Yet, his behavior was definitely out of their control and, at some level of awareness, *they knew it*. But they still believed and hoped that they might be able to change him. They believed they could control him.

All of the fundamental issues of codependency are present in this real-life example. In this chapter, we'd like you to examine *at least one and no more than three* of your problem relationships. You'll be asked if you want to make changes and then make a brief plan. Remember that this is **not** shared in group.

1. Identifying The Problem Relationships

In the numbered spaces below, list the identity (name, nickname) of at least one, and no more than three, people that you believe are *problem relationships* for you. Write exactly what the nature of this relationship is after their name. (Ex: My husband/wife; My father; My boyfriend.) Then answer the question: *Is this a codependent relationship?* (yes or no)

Relationship 1: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

Relationship 2: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

Relationship 3: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

2. What Are You Trying To Control?

In the spaces that follow, list whether you have been trying to control the behavior of the people you identified as problem relationships. (yes or no) Then write exactly what you have been trying to control. (Examples: drug use, crime, violence, anger, work behavior, love life.) Finally, answer this: do you believe you can control this behavior. (yes or no)

1. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____
2. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____
3. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____

3. What Are Your Unhealthy Behaviors?

In the spaces below, try to identify **your unhealthy behaviors** that have occurred because of this relationship. (Examples: I've lied for him; I make excuses.) Then answer the following questions.

1. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____
2. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____
3. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____

4. Is Your Self-Worth Related To These Relationships?

In the spaces below, decide if how you feel about yourself — your self-worth — has suffered because of this relationship. (yes or no) Then answer: “How has your self-worth suffered? What can you do to repair this damage?”

1. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

2. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

3. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and adequately discussed them with your facilitator, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 6 — Group 6

WILLINGNESS & WILLFULNESS: WHERE ARE YOU?

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. You will share your responses to the questions in group.]

Understanding the difference between being willing and being willful is important in looking at relationships. The first chapter told the story of the woman who called about her husband. She had tried “everything” to help him. But he couldn’t or wouldn’t stop doing drugs and stealing. He was “willing to do anything to change,” he just needed to find the right program that could *help him*.

A problem in this situation is the difference between being willing and being willful. Yes, he was “willing” to go to treatment. He had been in lots of treatments. He surely wanted his life to change for the better. But he wouldn’t put out any real effort to do what he had to do to change—he wasn’t willful. He placed the responsibility for his change on others. There is a simple, old story that relates to this.

There was this guy who was lying outside enjoying the sun. A storm approached with thunder and dark clouds. “I sure don’t want to get wet,” the guy said. The storm kept getting closer. “God, please don’t let me get wet,” he pleaded. But the storm hit and he was soaked. “You let me down, God. I really didn’t want to get wet.”

God replied, “I gave you legs and enough sense to get out of the rain, you have to have the will to use them.”

1. What Is Under Your Control?

In past chapters you looked at some things in your life that were under your control. List below three things under your control that are *very* important to you. (Examples: health, house, job, career, school.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

2. Are You Doing The Things You Need To Do?

Look at the three things you listed above. Are you doing everything you need to do to control each of them? (yes or no) Do you want (are you willing) to take charge and control of them? (yes or no) What is the first thing you have to do? When will you do this?

1. Are you doing everything you need to do to control #1? _____
Do you want (are you willing) to take charge and control of it? _____
What is the first thing you have to do? _____
When will you do this? (Date) _____
2. Are you doing everything you need to do to control #2? _____
Do you want (are you willing) to take charge and control of it? _____
What is the first thing you have to do? _____
When will you do this? (Date) _____

3. Are you doing everything you need to do to control #3? _____
Do you want (are you willing) to take charge and control of it? _____
What is the first thing you have to do? _____
When will you do this? (Date) _____

3. Not Everything You Do Is Wrong

There is probably no doubt that some areas in your life are going fairly well. You have the ability of coping with difficulties and being successful. Answer the questions below.

1. Name two areas in your life that are going well.
 1. _____
 2. _____
2. List two things that you did for others that really helped them.
 1. _____
 2. _____
3. How did helping these people make you feel?
 1. _____
 2. _____
4. Name two areas in your life where you need help from others.
 1. _____
 2. _____
5. How can you get that help?
 1. _____
 2. _____
6. List three things you do really well.
 1. _____
 2. _____
 3. _____
7. What is the one thing in life that you wish you could get paid to do? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 7 — Group 7

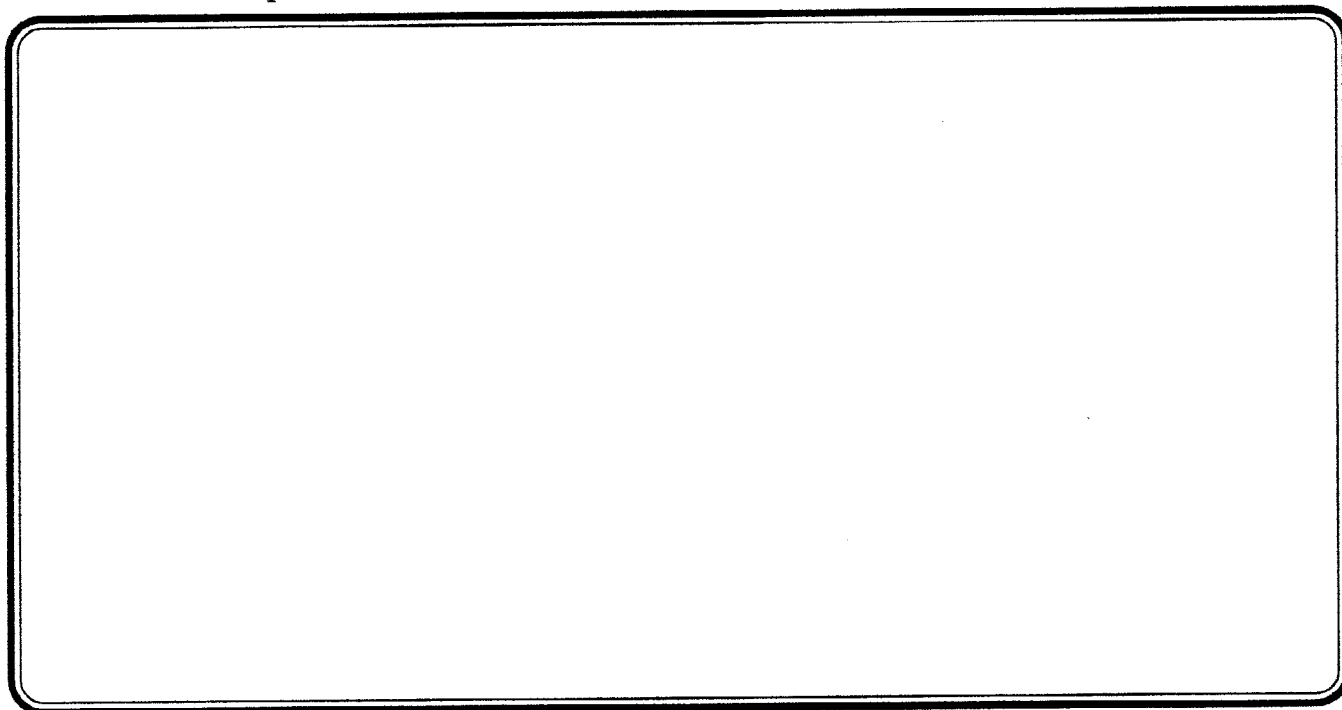
EXPLORING YOUR TRUE SELF

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. You will share your responses in group.]

As discussed in prior groups, one problem many people have in relationships is that they develop a false-self. Remember that the false-self develops because of codependent involvement with others. It is a negative pattern of behaviors, feelings, and ideas (beliefs) we form as we try to control negative relationships.

1. Drawing Your False-Self

In the space below, draw a picture of your false-self. Think about ways you act and emotions you feel that you sometimes believe or feel “aren’t really you.” Be sure to write some feelings of the false self, some behaviors, and some of its beliefs. For example, you might write: “My false-self feels empty without this other person.” “My false-self acts (behaves) as if I’m a jealous child.” “My false-self believes that I can’t survive without this person. It believes that I’m weak.”



My False-Self

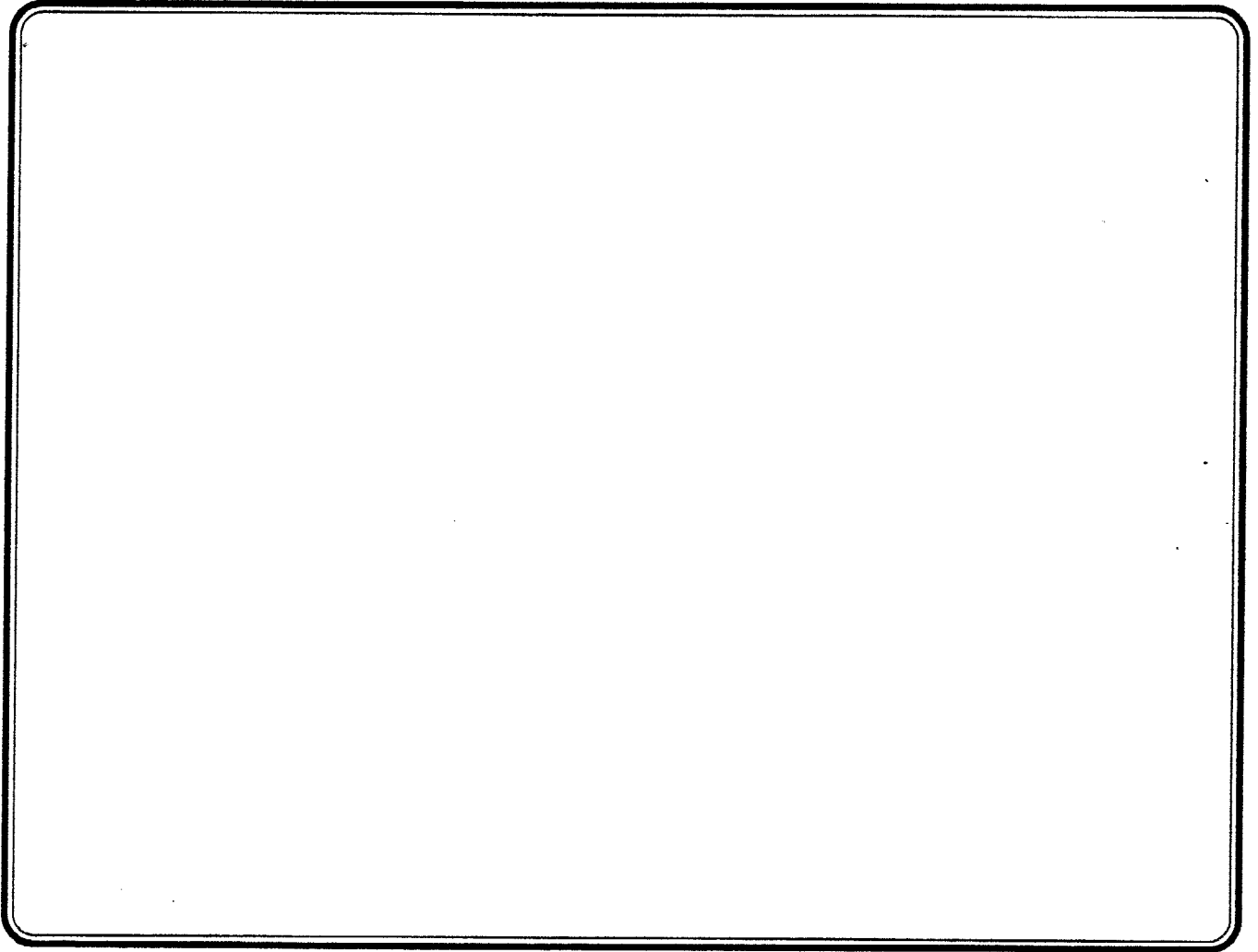
What are some of the behaviors that come from your false-self? _____

What are some feelings that come from your false-self? _____

What are some beliefs that come from your false-self? _____

2. Drawing Your Real-Self — Your Inner Self

In the space below, draw a picture of your real-self. Think about what and how you really are. Remember that the Inner Self contains your positive potentials — your abilities and aspirations to become the best you can be. It tells you that you can be successful and urges you to become better and better. Be sure to write some feelings of the real self, some behaviors, and some of its beliefs. For example, you might write: “My real-self feels I am a good person.” “My real-self acts (behaves) like I can do just about anything I want.” “My real-self believes that I can survive with or without that person. It believes that I’m strong.”



My Real-Self

What are some of the behaviors that come from your real-self? _____

What are some feelings that come from your real-self? _____

What are some beliefs that come from your real-self? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 8 — Group 8

WHAT'S MISSING?

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will not share your responses to the questions in group unless you ask the facilitator to allow you to do so.* Your facilitator will look over your work individually. You should participate in others' group discussions.]

People in codependent relationships often wrap everything in their lives around that relationship. In so doing, they lose sight of themselves as an individual—they sort of become the relationship. They often fail to recognize or acknowledge their choices, their needs, their desires, their feelings, and their goals. Answer the questions that follow. Remember that these should not be shared in group.

1. List five (5) things you **desire or want** in life.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

2. List five (5) things you really **need** in life.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

3. List five (5) **feelings** you have **that have not been expressed** to others.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

4. Think about your important relationships that are causing problems. What is it that you really want to get from these relationships? _____

5. Knowing what you now know, do you think you will get what you answered above (in #4) from those relationships? _____

6. Your real-self wants you to do some things. List 5 things it wants you to do.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with your facilitator, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 9 — Group 9

WHAT DO YOU WANT TO DO?

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will not share your responses to the questions in group unless you ask the facilitator to allow you to do so.* Your facilitator will look over your work individually. You should participate in others' group discussions.]

A person's identity in life — the person's self-image and self-worth — can be changed. Perhaps the simplest way to do this is to set goals. Next, you have to make some plans on how you intend to fulfill these goals. Finally, you have to follow through. This chapter concerns goals you have for yourself. In the space below, set 5 goals for yourself that you want to accomplish over the next year. Try to keep these very specific (like "I will buy a new car"). Then answer the two questions below each goal.

1. I will _____
What is the first thing you have to do to achieve this goal? _____

When will you do this? _____
2. I will _____
What is the first thing you have to do to achieve this goal? _____

When will you do this? _____
3. I will _____
What is the first thing you have to do to achieve this goal? _____

When will you do this? _____
4. I will _____
What is the first thing you have to do to achieve this goal? _____

When will you do this? _____
5. I will _____
What is the first thing you have to do to achieve this goal? _____

When will you do this? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with your facilitator, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 10 — Group 10

WHAT IS GETTING IN YOUR WAY?

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will share your responses to the questions in group.*]

Codependency is a wide-ranging set of negative behaviors and feelings that develop in an attempt to control others. Codependent people are 'entangled' in problematical relationships. Remember that these behaviors develop as a means of coping with negative relationships. In this chapter, you will be looking at some typical codependent behavior. Simply place a check mark by any that apply to you. In group, you will identify which ones you marked. The facilitator and other group members may have a few questions and comments for you.

- ☐ 1. Are you making threats to others?
- ☐ 2. Do you take pride in your sacrificing for others?
- ☐ 3. Are you allowing someone to abuse you?
- ☐ 4. Are you abusing others?
- ☐ 5. Do have feelings that a disaster is about to happen?
- ☐ 6. Do you dread losing a relationship?
- ☐ 7. Are you overly sensitive to others' feelings?
- ☐ 8. Are you working hard to get someone to love you?
- ☐ 9. Do you think others are making you crazy?
- ☐ 10. Is your self-esteem in others' hands?
- ☐ 11. Do you avoid discussing your needs?
- ☐ 12. Do you have important unexpressed feelings?
- ☐ 13. Are you afraid of being alone?
- ☐ 14. Do you feel that you'd be a nobody if you were alone?
- ☐ 15. Are you depressed?
- ☐ 16. Do you suffer from anxiety?
- ☐ 17. Do you dread "tomorrow" each night?
- ☐ 18. Are you doing things for others that they should be doing for themselves?
- ☐ 19. Are others doing things for you that you should be doing for yourself?
- ☐ 20. Do you believe you can change your partner?
- ☐ 21. Do you feel responsible for others' behaviors and feelings?
- ☐ 22. Do you say yes to people when you want to say no?
- ☐ 23. Do you care more about pleasing others than pleasing yourself?
- ☐ 24. Do you feel pressured to get things done?
- ☐ 25. Do you worry about silly things?
- ☐ 26. Do you sometimes feel life is empty and not worth living?
- ☐ 27. Do you take things personally?
- ☐ 28. Do you feel hurt, rejected, or like a victim?
- ☐ 29. Are you afraid of making mistakes?
- ☐ 30. Are you ashamed of being yourself?

How many of the above did you check? _____ Do you want to work on any of these issues? _____
Which ones? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses in group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.

Chapter 11 — Group 11

ONLY YOU CONTROL WHAT YOU DO

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will share your responses to the questions in group.*]

This small workbook has repeatedly stated that each of us only controls ourselves and our behavior. And some people don't do a very good job at that. So, how do you feel about your relationships now? Do you feel your life and your relationships are out of your control? Do you have some genuine acceptance about what you can and cannot control? Do you feel better about yourself?

Untangling yourself from problem relationships is a way of gaining freedom to become yourself. Sometimes people are so wrapped up in others' problems that they lose themselves. They become a false person — trapped by misguided attempts to control. Once you understand how you have become tangled in others' feelings and behavior, you can become free to explore your own abilities and desires. Hopefully, you have more than begun that process and are well on your way to real happiness and meaning in your life.

The purpose of this program has not been to have you terminate your problem relationships. However, it may be that ending a relationship is the right thing to do — and the only good choice. But our bigger purpose was to have you take control of yourself and to become realistic about how much you can control others. Your happiness rests on your shoulders. It is foolish to place your happiness and purpose in life in another person's hands.

1. Good Times & Bad Times

Begin this exercise by listing the 5 best times you have ever had with other people. Think about all of your life and write something about each experience below.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Now, list the 5 worst times you have ever had with other people. Think about all of your life and write something about each experience below.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

In looking at your 5 good times, how much control did you have? Did you cause the experience? Did you have a good, acceptant attitude? What was it that made each good time so good? Answer these questions below. _____

In looking at your 5 bad times, how much control did you have? Did you cause the experience? Did you have a negative attitude? What was it that made each bad time so bad? Answer these questions below. In group, you will be asked to answer a few questions about what you wrote.

2. Where Do You Think You Are Right Now?

Before ending this chapter, the next to last in the program, you need to take a good look at yourself and your relationships. *You do not have to share everything* you write here in group.

Do you believe you have made any progress in problem relationships since you entered this program?

Is there something else can you do to work on your problem relationships? _____

Look back at the things you checked in Chapter 10 (page 24). Which of those issues do you believe you need to work on? _____

Do you need to ask the group or your facilitator to point you in the direction of more help? _____

Is there anything you want to say to the facilitator? _____

Do you want to meet individually with the group facilitator? _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses in group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter. Remember that you do not have to share all of the things you wrote in the last section of this chapter.

Chapter 12 — Group 12

PROGRAM END

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Make a few notes for yourself before coming to group. *In group you will stand up and speak for a few moments.*]

In a simple way, this brief program has only taken you to the point of making some decisions and hopefully starting to carry them out. You have the right to change your mind as circumstances and conditions change, but you should try to do what is best for you and those you have relationships with. Take responsibility for yourself first. Seek more help. Coping with relationships is a never-ending process.

It is our hope that you have made some progress and understand relationships better. We also hope that you are a little happier and have less stress. At the same time, we need to caution you that there are people in your group who will see you as a role model. They can get hope, inspiration, and help from you. This chapter, and your final group meeting, represent an opportunity for you to help others while you make commitments to yourself. Take some time and prepare a few notes to yourself about the 6 issues listed below. In group, you will be asked to stand up for a few minutes (no more than 15) and address each issue. You may look at your notes as you speak, but you shouldn't just read. Speak to the group from your heart. After you have finished, the facilitator may allow a few questions. You have our best wishes.

The Things Your Talk Must Address

1. What you thought about codependence when you first entered this group. _____

2. What codependence means to you now. _____

3. What you have learned about your problem relationships. _____

4. How you feel about yourself now, and how you felt when you first entered. _____

5. What are some of the things you have accepted as truth about yourself and your relationships. _____

6. What are the things you really control in your life. _____
